
On the Subject of Ravens

It is said that in the time before, the world was without ravens, that the skies were empty of the watchers, those that waited, those that cross.

Then came blood, and fire, and warfare and the world changed. Magics that flowed between realms became barricaded, purposely re-routed, taken away from the Human Realm to further feed the land of the Fae, despite it being the source of all magics.

And those stranded mourned and wept, for they had lost something bigger than their homeland. Displacement was nothing compared to their families torn apart, each sealed on either side of the Barrier, cast adrift from custom and culture.

But the Underkin did not go quietly. Despite their diminutive size, they were underestimated by the Fae, and so, one desperate night, having being wrenched from his family, the Rune Bearer Tharnial Blackwing called out to the birds of his clan.

One, snow-white dove answered his call and alighted upon the window ledge, his eyes bright and intelligent, feeling the pain of his clansman.

The dove looked at Tharnial, and the bird's voice rang clear in his mind. "I can take you there, but not in your current form."

"How?" asked Tharnial, suspicious after many years of lies and persecution.

The dove cooed, a sort of laugh. "They did not check the barrier for whether we could cross. We have existed for as long as magic has been part of our worlds and we hold the purest of magics and so the Barrier does not see us."

The dove held Tharnial's gaze with its tiny, black eyes, tilting his head to the side as though listening.

"Why would you help me?" asked Tharnial, looking for evidence that this was a trap, a scheme by a tricky Fae for their evil entertainment.

"I can assure you this is a gift freely given, Tharnial Blackwing. But it will only be offered once, and you must decide now."

"You said 'not in my current form'... what did you mean?" asked Tharnial, eyes narrow and sharp.

"You shall bind yourself to me, and that of your clan, for the rest of this age. You shall no longer be Underkin or Rune Bearers, but rather a new sort of Watcher. One that can pass between realms. It is a duty that will last for generations, until there comes a time when Ravens are no longer needed.

"Ravens? What are ravens?" asked Tharnial, for he knew of no such creature in the Human or Fae Realm.

"They are what we will become, together, should you accept my proposal."

"And I will be able to travel between the Realms? See my family?"

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"You will," replied the dove, "but you will be as I am, a creature of flight and wing. Do you accept the cost?"

"The cost... my whole family will be... changed?"

"Yes. Your whole family, for as long as needed. Come now, I must press you for an answer as the sun is rising and this is a spell that must be cast before dawn."

Tharnial stood up straight and looked around the little cottage he called home; the stove and kitchen table, the tools of his Rune Bearer trade and realised that he would miss nothing. His family, however, he would give anything to see them again, regardless of what his wills and wants might cost them.

He nodded. "I shall come with you, bird of my clan, and bind myself and my family to you for as long as there is need of Ravens."

The dove flew from his window perch to the table and Tharnial sat down opposite. A few words from the dove in a Henluith spell so old it has been forgotten, and Tharnial felt himself dissolve into something new entirely.

He tried out his new eyes and found that he could see for great distances. He stretched out his arms and discovered he had wings with the strength to fly. He laughed, delighted.

"I am here, too," came the voice of the dove. "We shall live as a bonded pair until our time runs out. Are you ready to cross now, to see your family? I have the rest of the flock ready and waiting to cross."

"Yes!" cried Tharnial in delight as they took flight together. They soared over the little cottage as more and more snow-white birds joined them.

It was only then that the Rune Bearer noticed the transformation in the dove; its snow-white wings had become as black as night.

Raven, thought the dove. We are Raven.

